

threats. For instance, as we mentioned, after graduating top of his class from Brown University in 2000, 23-year-old Raphael de Rothschild, scion of one of the world's wealthiest families, died of a heroin overdose at a friend's apartment in Manhattan.

Families with a strong matriarch and strong institutions, such as an active Family Council, do not avoid these problems. But perhaps they can detect problems sooner; they are usually in closer and more frequent communication with one another. Whether they can do anything about the problem is another question.

Once a problem is detected, concerned family members should deal it with privately. We're no experts on this, either. But one route is to have a procedure already spelled out in the family constitution. Then, without making judgments on any particular family member, you can merely apply the rules as necessary. There are no guarantees that this will help the troublesome family member, but it will protect the rest of the family and its resources.

The Family Council can allocate funds for treatment and other health-related matters. Beyond that, the Family Council should stick to its wealth-oriented mission and avoid getting involved in personal, emotionally charged issues.

Notes

[1.](#) "Iphigene Ochs Is Dead; Central Figure in Times's History," *New York Times*, Feb. 27, 1990.

[2.](#) Niall Ferguson, *The House of Rothschild, Vol. 1: Money's Prophets, 1798–1848* (New York: Penguin Books, 1998).

[3.](#) Miriam Rothschild, "The Silent Members of the First EEC: Family Reflections. II: The Women," *The Rothschilds: Essays on the History of a European Family* (ed. Georg Heuberger) (Woodbridge, England: Boydell & Brewer), 155–164.

[4.](#) Ferguson.